



TOOLBOX TALK — WEEKLY SAFETY MEETING

Millwork | Carpentry | Interior Finishes | Material Handling

WEEK 13

Date: Supervisor:

Project / Job Name:

TOPIC: Router & Router Table Safety

OVERVIEW:

Routers are among the highest-speed tools in the millwork trade, operating at 20,000 RPM or more. At these speeds, a bit failure is not just a broken tool — it is an explosion. Fragments travel at bullet speeds and have caused fatalities. Router safety requires discipline around bit selection,

TALKING POINTS — Read to Crew:

1. Router bit selection and inspection is your first critical step. Inspect every bit before use for cracks, missing carbide inserts, damaged shanks, or any sign of previous overheating such as discoloration. A damaged bit running at 20,000 RPM does not fail slowly — it fails all at once. Never exceed the maximum RPM rating printed on the bit packaging, and always match the bit to the
2. Bit installation must be done with precision. Insert the bit shank fully into the collet, then pull it back out approximately 1/16 inch before tightening. This ensures the shank is not bottomed out, which can cause the collet to crack and fail to grip properly. Use two wrenches to tighten the collet nut — one on the collet nut and one on the spindle lock. A loose bit is a projectile.
3. Feed direction determines whether the router cuts cleanly or grabs the workpiece. Conventional milling means feeding the router against the rotation of the bit — this is the correct direction for almost all work. Climb cutting — feeding with the rotation — can produce a smoother cut but can violently grab the workpiece and pull the router out of your hands. Never climb-cut without
4. On a router table, featherboards are essential. They hold the workpiece against the fence and table surface so that the bit cannot grab and pull the piece out of your hands. Never rout freehand on a table without featherboards. Use push sticks and push blocks for narrow stock. Keep your fingers away from the bit path at all times, and never reach over or behind the bit while the router is

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS — Ask Your Crew:

- Q1: How do you determine the correct feed direction for a router operation?
Q2: What is the procedure on this job if you find a router bit that shows signs of damage?

KEY SAFETY POINTS:

- Never exceed the maximum RPM rating printed on any bit
- Secure bits fully — 1/8 inch of shank outside collet is the maximum
- Allow router to reach full speed before contacting any workpiece
- Feed against the bit rotation for conventional cuts — not with it
- Use featherboards and push sticks on all router table operations

Crew sign-in sheet on page 2 — all 30 crew members sign on the following page.



CREW SIGN-IN SHEET

WEEK 13

By signing, I confirm I attended this toolbox talk and understand the topic discussed.

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